



Life with your **new baby** is full of novel experiences, intense emotions, and **positive changes**. It also brings with it many new **responsibilities** and considerations, and you will find that you need to **plan ahead** far more than you did in the past.

Planning for the future

Thinking ahead to work

One of the main considerations when taking time off with your baby is when, or if, you plan to return to work after the birth. You may have already set a date with your employer, though you might change your mind about this date when you are on leave—maybe wanting to return earlier for financial reasons, or to take an extended period of time off. Many women take three months of maternity leave. Whether or not it's paid depends on your company's policy. With the Family and Medical Leave Act, many people can get three months of unpaid leave. Individual employers may have their own terms and offers, so discuss these with yours. If you plan to return to work, arranging child care early on means you can relax and enjoy precious time with your baby.

A growing family

After a certain period of time, and once you are settled in with your new family unit, you and your partner might start to think about adding a new addition to the family, providing a sibling for your baby. There are so many

reasons for and against different age gaps between siblings, and you may feel that some of these are worth considering. Essentially, though, if you and your partner feel ready emotionally, physically, and financially for this step, the time could be right to try to become pregnant again. Keep discussions open with your partner so that you are aware of each other's feelings and expectations, and any differences of opinion can be talked through.

Changes to the home

Now that you are three, it's natural to reevaluate your home setup and consider how well this works for your new family unit. Perhaps you are thinking about a move to a new area where you can get a larger home for your money, which is something many parents consider in the preschool years. Or if a move isn't on the agenda, you might think about changes you can make to your existing home. Keep in mind that your child will feel happy wherever she is as long as she is surrounded by love and has good care, so don't feel you have to make changes to your home if it is likely that these are going to be stressful or financially challenging.